

IMPACT REPORT

COOL AI SH*T

Baltimore Summit · 2025



FROM THE ORGANIZERS

Dear friends,

Thank you for joining us at the inaugural Cool AI Sh*t Summit. Whether you spoke, listened, questioned, or quietly absorbed — it mattered. Together, we carved out space to ask the big, messy, exciting questions that too often get buried beneath jargon or urgency.

What we saw in Baltimore was clear: our community is not content to be passengers in this AI journey. We want a steering wheel. We want to shape the future, not just react to it.

But shaping the future takes more than hot takes and hashtags. It takes collaboration, accountability, and the courage to dream about what could be — then do the hard work of building it.

That's why we're inviting you to take the next step. We're forming a Working Group for a Progressive AI Future — a collective of nonprofit leaders, technologists, creatives, and organizers who want to craft an alternative vision for how AI can serve humanity. Our first goal? To respond to the AI Futures Project's challenge by submitting a new scenario — one that centers equity, community resilience, and the right to real choice, inspired by Amartya Sen's vision of *Development as Freedom*.

If you left this summit energized, curious, or even uneasy — that's your signal. Join us.

Together, we can make this moment more than a trend. We can make it a turning point.

In solidarity and imagination,

Ben, Maan, and Eric

Co-founders, Stratovation Partners



COMMON THEMES AND CONTRADICTIONS

The inaugural Cool AI Sh*t summit in Baltimore was a lively convergence of ideas, optimism, and realism surrounding artificial intelligence's transformative potential for nonprofits, creative agencies, and advocacy organizations. Attendees engaged deeply with the promise and pitfalls of AI, framing a vision that was distinctly human-centered and context-aware.

SEVERAL PREVALENT THEMES EMERGED

Contextual relevance

Tareq, Bree and Tom emphasized tailoring AI to the unique internal landscape of an individual organization. Generic tools may be technically impressive, yet their effectiveness is severely limited without precise contextual integration. Jen Frazier's peer-learning session underscored it, and Sohini's perspectives on nuanced communication reinforced that context is not merely beneficial but essential.

Empowering small teams

Maan showcased AI increasing productivity through automation and predictive analytics, transforming limited resources into powerful outcomes. Eric and his co-panelists described how generative AI enables rapid content creation and strategy formulation, democratizing capabilities previously limited to larger organizations.

Ethical nuance and responsibility

Data privacy, intellectual property and the risks of AI-generated content were frequent discussion points. Leah's exploration of design tools surfaced concerns around bias and ownership; Chris's examination of open-source platforms raised transparency and governance questions. Sal provided evidence that responsibly implemented AI maintains trust and can enhance donor engagement.

Authenticity and human connection

Michael Hoffman articulated why genuine human storytelling remains paramount in nonprofit marketing and advocacy. Sohini echoed it, highlighting how AI-driven efficiency must complement, not replace, the deeply human qualities of curiosity, empathy and creativity.



CONTRADICTIONS AND TENSIONS

Contradictions and tensions enriched the dialogue, providing balanced perspectives and acknowledging the real complexities of AI adoption.

Accessibility versus expertise

Leah advocated for the democratizing power of user-friendly AI tools, allowing even small teams to create professional-level designs. Chris warned of the risks when simplified platforms obscure technical complexity, potentially leading to misuse or misinterpretation. Both viewpoints underscored the need for balance between user-friendliness and responsible oversight.

Efficiency versus brand integrity

While attendees acknowledged AI's role in streamlining content creation, Jen's session surfaced concerns about losing distinctive organizational voices when relying on automated generation. Sohini argued for robust human oversight to ensure authenticity, suggesting efficiency gains must never overshadow cultural and strategic identity.

Innovation versus practical constraints

Enthusiasm for innovation, as presented by Maan's automation solutions, often collided with the realities of limited budgets, messy data ecosystems and fragmented organizational practices. This tension emphasized strengthening foundational structures before ambitious AI deployments.

NO CONSENSUS

Ultimately, the summit concluded without a singular consensus — an outcome embraced positively by participants. This absence of unanimity signaled a healthy ecosystem of experimentation, dialogue and mutual learning.

The diversity of perspectives indicated a readiness within the community to actively shape the trajectory of AI in ways that align with their mission-driven values. Rather than resolving all debates, the summit set a precedent for ongoing collaboration.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS

The sessions offered a wide-ranging view into how AI is reshaping work across the nonprofit, creative and advocacy sectors. From deeply technical insights to community-driven storytelling, each speaker illuminated a different facet of what it means to engage with AI responsibly and creatively.

Tareq Alani

CO-FOUNDER, CHORUS AI

Addressed the profound importance of organizational context in nonprofit AI implementations. His team's approach — securely integrating an organization's existing data and permissions — presented AI as a strategic partner, not just a tool. Emphasizing semantic search and retrieval-augmented generation, Tareq demonstrated that effective AI must deeply understand an organization's unique operational landscape.



Michael Hoffman

FOUNDER & CEO, GATHER VOICES

A passionate defense of human storytelling amid AI-driven content production. He argued for authenticity over perfection, using real-world examples to illustrate how authentic, human-centered narratives outperform synthetic content in nonprofit campaigns. His exploration of AI video tools underscored the value of augmenting, not supplanting, human-driven stories.



Bree Benn & Tom Spencer

CO-FOUNDERS, ADVOCACYAI

A critical and humorous examination of the current AI hype cycle, cautioning attendees against uncritical adoption. Their session encouraged participants to become proficient "BS detectors," emphasizing context, critical questioning and ethical vigilance as key skills for responsible AI engagement within nonprofits.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS, CONTINUED

Leah Caldwell

CMO, ENGINE9

Introduced a curated selection of seven innovative AI design tools, from beginner-friendly platforms like Canva to sophisticated generators like Midjourney and Adobe Firefly. Highlighting both their practical capabilities and ethical implications, Leah provided a balanced exploration of how these tools democratize access to professional-quality design while underscoring the human oversight needed to maintain authenticity and manage bias.

Sohini Baliga

HEAD OF MARKETING, NATIONAL DEMOCRATIC TRAINING COMMITTEE

Eloquently framed AI as a valuable yet incomplete partner, incapable of fully replicating human judgment, creativity and cultural sensitivity. Sharing insights from her own organization, she illustrated how thoughtful human oversight remains critical to successful AI deployments, reinforcing the necessity of maintaining human-centric strategies alongside technological innovation.

Chris Lundberg

CEO, ENGINE9

Delved into the democratization of AI via open-source models like Stable Diffusion and Llama, examining implications for governance, accessibility and societal impact. His session expanded attendees' understanding of AI as not only cloud-based technology but also accessible, customizable tools that empower broader participation. He also surfaced the AI 2027 report, later used by Ben in his call to action, to point out the possibility of a radically transformed world in a very short period.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS, CONTINUED

Maan Sacdalan

CO-FOUNDER, STRATOVATION PARTNERS

Shared practical applications of AI and automation, demonstrating significant productivity gains in resource-constrained environments. Examples such as predictive sentiment analysis and smart email triage illustrated tangible benefits of thoughtfully implemented automation, showing nonprofits that strategic AI investments could yield meaningful operational improvements without overwhelming teams.

Jen Frazier

FOUNDER & CEO, FIREFLY PARTNERS

Transformed her session into an interactive peer-learning experience, inviting attendees to share their AI adoption journeys and challenges. The format surfaced collective wisdom around balancing AI's efficiency with organizational authenticity, revealing insights into practical applications and ethical considerations from diverse perspectives within the nonprofit sector.

Sal Salpietro

CHIEF COMMUNITY OFFICER, FUNDRAISE UP

Presented compelling benchmarking data showcasing the substantial impact AI-driven personalization can have on donor experiences. His findings demonstrated AI's potential for significant enhancements in nonprofit fundraising outcomes, especially via mobile platforms, provided ethical privacy standards and thoughtful user experience design are rigorously upheld.

Closing panel

**JEN NEWMAYER (PBS) · THELMA ANDREE (FRESH EYES DIGITAL) ·
MODERATED BY ERIC RUBIN**

Candidly discussed the intersection of AI, creativity and organizational strategy, acknowledging both the transformative power and the enduring human challenges of AI adoption. Their dialogue emphasized that while AI offers exciting opportunities, true effectiveness requires structural alignment, ethical transparency and thoughtful integration into existing strategic frameworks.



WITH THANKS

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COOL/SCARY AI

A national series of community-centered
conversations about AI's real impact,
produced by Stratovation Partners.

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